accused the scientists of being an incompetent and ‘lazy bunch, eager for money’, and claimed things would change ‘when he took over’ the Central Committee Secretariat for Science and Culture.

Incensed, professors protested to Honecker. A week later, Naumann was confronted and accused in a tense Politburo session but denied everything, complaining he had become the victim of slander. However, when Honecker tartly responded by producing a mini-Dictaphone containing a tape-recording of the academy outburst, Naumann punched back by calling Honecker an ‘impotent dwarf’. Like an arsonist firefighter, Naumann went on to say that he enjoyed the support of Berlin construction workers who would tear down the ‘Politburo residences in Wandlitz, the ghetto of the prominent people.’ Honecker answered tersely: ‘He who speaks like that is sick.’ Five minutes later Naumann was out of a job.

A slightly different version of events from Professor Herbert Meissner, a Fellow from the Academy of Sciences, added granular detail to the incident.10 Interviewed by the BND in 1986, he claimed Honecker was to be overthrown by Naumann and the ‘Kremlin was said to have agreed’. In Meissner’s version, Egon Krenz was to be installed as First Secretary, but the putsch attempt collapsed during the aforementioned showdown. As to Honecker’s reaction at the ‘impotent dwarf’ jibe, Meissner said the First Secretary shook his head and shrieked: ‘There have been people for decades who have tried to oppose me. It did them no good. Get out of here!’ In his memoirs, Günter Schabowski noted ‘Naumann was a keen drinker but not a hard drinker – he bragged about his plans as general secretary. He already had the list for his Politburo ready.’11 He had few scruples, according to Schabowski, despite having been close to Honecker since the 1950s. ‘Honecker is now firmly determined to stay in office at least until the 1991 party congress,’ Meissner told the BND. ‘He feels fit aside from high blood pressure because of his age. Moreover, he wants to fulfil one wish. After the 1987 Bundestag elections, he wants to come to the FRG to see the Saarland, his homeland, once again.’ (Günter Schabowski became the new East Berlin party chief in place of Naumann)